

When Nights Don't Cool Down: The Hidden Danger of the Current Heat Wave

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-07-02 5 min read

As a punishing **heat dome** bakes the Midwest and Atlantic Coast, threatening up to 90 million Americans with record-breaking daytime temperatures, a less visible danger is unfolding after sunset: nights are not cooling down. In the Baltimore-D.C. region and southeastern Pennsylvania, **overnight lows** are expected to hover in the low 80s temperatures that offer little relief and significantly increase the risk of **heat exhaustion** and heat stroke.

"We're seeing temperatures well into the evening that are staying shockingly high and, in some cases, never dropping below 80 or 75 degrees. And this is really concerning," says Ashley Ward, director of the Heat Policy Innovation Hub at Duke University. She emphasizes that overnight recovery is crucial not just for human bodies but for animals and energy infrastructure. Without it, the next day's heat builds on an already stressed system.

Climate change is a key driver. The **Fifth National Climate Assessment** notes that nighttime temperatures are rising faster than daytime ones in the U.S., and the number of nights where the temperature never falls below 70°F is increasing almost everywhere except the Northern Great Plains. Meteorologist Alex DaSilva of Accuweather explains that the atmosphere is retaining more heat at night, and more humid conditions also linked to climate change compound the problem. "It can even feel worse sometimes after a rain shower or a thunderstorm comes through," he says, because high humidity makes it harder for sweat to evaporate and cool the body.

The danger is especially acute for the estimated 12% of U.S. households without air conditioning. A KFF study found that Asian, Black, and Hispanic households, as well as lower-income households, are more likely to lack AC. Older adults and those with **comorbidities** like heart disease or diabetes are most vulnerable. For those who must be outdoors, experts recommend gradual **acclimatization** and staying hydrated before, during, and after exposure. As one expert puts it, "Make sure they drink before their heat exposure and especially afterward to try to catch up."

Word Treasure

heat dome -- A large area of high pressure that traps hot air for days, causing dangerously high temperatures even at night.

overnight lows -- The lowest temperature reached during the night, important for allowing bodies and buildings to cool down.

heat exhaustion -- A heat-related illness with symptoms like heavy sweating, weakness, and dizziness, caused by the body overheating.

Fifth National Climate Assessment -- A major U.S. government report released in 2023 that summarizes how climate change is affecting the country now and in the future.

acclimatization -- The process of gradually getting used to heat so the body can handle hot

conditions more safely over time.

comorbidities -- Other health conditions a person already has, like heart disease or diabetes, that make it harder to cope with heat stress.

Background you need

The heat island effect makes cities even hotter at night because concrete and asphalt release stored heat after sunset--a phenomenon first documented in the 19th century.

Ashley Ward directs Duke University's Heat Policy Innovation Hub, which works on solutions to protect communities from extreme heat, especially those without air conditioning.

KFF, formerly the Kaiser Family Foundation, is a non-profit organization that researches health policy; its studies often highlight racial and income disparities in health risks.

World Weather Attribution, an international research group, has found that climate change made recent extreme heat waves at least five times more likely in some regions.

Older adults and people with chronic illnesses face higher heat risks because their bodies struggle to regulate temperature, a fact that public health officials emphasize during warnings.

Break it down

LEAD: Hidden danger after sunset--nights are not cooling down

+ SPECIFIC: Baltimore-DC region and southeastern Pennsylvania, lows in the 80s

EXPERT WARNING: Ashley Ward--overnight recovery crucial for humans, animals, energy systems

CLIMATE DRIVER: warmer nights linked to climate change, Fifth National Climate Assessment

+ EVIDENCE: nighttime temps rising faster than daytime across most of US

+ METEOROLOGIST: Alex DaSilva of Accuweather explains humidity worsens the feel, rain doesn't always cool

SOCIAL DISPARITY: 12% of US households lack AC

+ KFF STUDY: Asian, Black, Hispanic and lower-income households more affected

+ VULNERABLE GROUPS: older adults, those with comorbidities (heart disease, diabetes)

ADAPTATION ADVICE: gradual acclimatization, hydration before, during, after exposure

OPEN QUESTION: Are communities prepared for rising nighttime heat that never lets up?

Why it matters

With nighttime heat now rising faster than daytime heat, the body's critical recovery hours disappear, making heat waves deadlier. This trend demands better access to cooling, updated warning systems, and urban design changes to reduce heat retention--issues that will affect how and where we live as the planet warms.

Test what you remember

1. In which region are overnight lows expected to hover in the low 80s during this heat wave?
 - (A) Northern Great Plains
 - (B) Baltimore-D.C. and southeastern Pennsylvania
 - (C) Dallas-Fort Worth
 - (D) Pacific Northwest
2. What is Ashley Ward's role at Duke University?
 - (A) Meteorologist
 - (B) Director of the Heat Policy Innovation Hub
 - (C) Emergency room doctor
 - (D) Climate change researcher at NOAA
3. What key driver does the article name for rising nighttime temperatures?
 - (A) Urban expansion
 - (B) Ocean currents
 - (C) Climate change
 - (D) Deforestation
4. According to the Fifth National Climate Assessment, what is happening to nighttime temperatures in the U.S.?
 - (A) They are falling slightly
 - (B) They are rising faster than daytime ones
 - (C) They are staying the same
 - (D) They are rising only in cities
5. Which groups are more likely to lack air conditioning, according to the KFF study mentioned?
 - (A) Asian, Black, and Hispanic households, and lower-income households
 - (B) White and higher-income households
 - (C) Rural households only
 - (D) Middle-class families with young children
6. What do experts recommend for people who must be outdoors during extreme heat?
 - (A) Wear dark clothing and exercise heavily
 - (B) Gradual acclimatization and staying hydrated before, during, and after exposure
 - (C) Stay still and avoid water
 - (D) Only go out in the early morning

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive:** Public health experts and meteorologists are raising awareness about nighttime heat dangers, helping people take protective actions. Better forecasts and advice can reduce emergency room visits and save lives during extreme events.
- 2. Negative / Critical:** The article reveals a deep inequality: low-income and minority communities are far more likely to lack air conditioning, leaving them vulnerable while wealthier groups stay cool. This gap shows how heat waves can worsen existing social injustices.
- 3. Neutral / Analytical:** Faster-warming nights are a clear signal predicted by climate models, showing that the atmosphere holds more moisture and heat. This pattern means that heat waves will not just get hotter, but also last longer without relief, changing what 'normal' summer weather looks like.
- 4. Forward-looking:** Cities may need to invest in public cooling centers, require air conditioning in new housing, and adjust school and work hours during heat waves. Long-term, shifting to renewable energy and reducing emissions can slow the warming, but adaptation is already urgent for communities on the front line.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):